

[Robert Walton](#), the captain of a ship bound for the North Pole, writes a letter to his sister, [Margaret Saville](#), in which he says that his crew members recently discovered a man adrift at sea. The man, [Victor Frankenstein](#), offered to tell Walton his story.

Frankenstein has a perfect childhood in Switzerland, with a loving family that even adopted orphans in need, including the beautiful [Elizabeth](#), who soon becomes Victor's closest friend, confidante, and love. Victor also has a caring and wonderful best friend, [Henry Clerval](#). Just before Victor turns seventeen and goes to study at the University at Ingolstadt, his mother dies of scarlet fever. At Ingolstadt, Victor dives into "natural philosophy" with a passion, studying the secrets of life with such zeal that he even loses touch with his family. He soon rises to the top of his field, and suddenly, one night, discovers the secret of life. With visions of creating a new and noble race, Victor puts his knowledge to work. But when he animates his first creature, its appearance is so horrifying he abandons it. Victor hopes the monster has disappeared for ever, but some months later he receives word that his youngest brother, William, has been murdered. Though Victor sees the monster lingering at the site of the murder and is sure it did the deed, he fears no one will believe him and keeps silent. [Justine](#)

[Moritz](#), another adoptee in his family, has been falsely accused based of the crime. She is convicted and executed. Victor is consumed by guilt.